additional consideration was that the country's economy was flourishing, including in the Galilee. The main source of income for the Galilee communities was tourism in the form of *tzimmerim,* the bed-and-breakfasts that were popping up throughout the pastoral area. Quiet along the northern border therefore became increasingly important. Prime Minister Ariel Sharon also gave other issues higher priority than Lebanon; at first he was engaged in the building of the separation fence in Judea and Samaria, and later he was busy with the disengagement from the Gaza Strip. From a philosophical point of view, it is possible that Sharon suffered from "Lebanon syndrome," for which he paid the price of his post as defense minister in 1982. There were also those who said—with an arrogance that not all of us Israelis are immune to—"Let Hezbollah collect all the iron bars they want—they'll all rust anyway!" For the record, intelligence provided an accurate picture of Hezbollah's military buildup: that is, there was no surprise.

Against this backdrop, a dynamic developed between Israel and Hezbollah, resulting in a de facto balance of fear between a guerrilla organization of several thousand fighters and the most powerful army in the Middle East.

What happened in the war itself?

Sheikh Hassan Nasrallah anticipated that the abduction of the two IDF soldiers would lead to two or three days of exchanges of fire, followed by negotiations on prisoner exchanges, as had been the case in similar situations since the withdrawal from Lebanon in 2001. This assessment was completely mistaken, as he openly admitted after the war.

Nasrallah did not appreciate that Israel had a new leadership that, while not possessing military experience, was also not captive to the conceptions of the past. This leadership decided that the balance of fear that had been building up since 2001 was no longer tolerable and had to be stopped. Of course, the force of the immediate response was also due to the fact that we'd had eight soldiers killed in the incident in addition to the two kidnapped soldiers.

For the first time since 2001, Israel challenged the balance of fear, the instigator of which was not Hezbollah, which served only as a tool, but Iran and Syria. The Israeli response also disrupted Iran's plans; Iran had built up Hezbollah in order to use it when the conditions and circumstances were convenient, and now things had blown up in their faces.